

Higher Education and Research English Dialogue Lab

Realistic field-specific dialogues, role-play variations, and observer checklists

Audience: faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders

Focus: A higher education and research English curriculum for grant proposals, lab meetings, peer review, research ethics, authorship, data management, academic presentations, and institutional collaboration.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Dialogue Practice Method

Read each exchange once for meaning, once for tone, and once for decision structure. Then complete the missing language by selecting one of four options and check the rationale at the end.

1. Research Questions and Study Design

Setting

A lab wants to describe an exploratory study as definitive.

Speaker	Line
Principal investigator	Use stronger language to attract attention.
Postdoc	Hypothesis, design, sample, limitations, and inference must be aligned.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm research question, hypothesis, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Principal investigator	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short study-design caveat. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: research question, hypothesis.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects hypothesis.

Option	Phrase
A	hypothesis
B	research question
C	operating constraint
D	decision owner

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Use stronger language to attract attention.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify research question and hypothesis against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	I disagree, but I cannot name the boundary or the decision the group needs to make.

Option	Phrase
D	evidence threshold

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A lab wants to describe an exploratory study as definitive. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	evidence threshold
B	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the study-design caveat with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
C	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.
D	Wait for the problem to become visible before assigning an owner or evidence source.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

2. Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

Setting

A proposal includes too many objectives for the budget.

Speaker	Line
Grant writer	Keep every aim to look comprehensive.
Principal investigator	Feasibility, significance, innovation, approach, and milestones need balance.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm specific aims, significance, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Grant writer	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short specific-aims revision. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: specific aims, significance.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects significance.

Option	Phrase
A	feasibility

Option	Phrase
B	evidence threshold
C	specific aims
D	innovation

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Keep every aim to look comprehensive.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	I understand the urgency. I need to verify specific aims and significance against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
B	operating constraint
C	decision owner
D	We should act now and resolve specific aims after the result is visible.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A proposal includes too many objectives for the budget. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Accept the request immediately because the stakeholder has already expressed urgency.
B	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the specific-aims revision with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
C	operating constraint
D	decision owner

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

3. Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

Setting

A student presents inconsistent results.

Speaker	Line
Lab manager	Say the data are bad.
Graduate student	Controls, replication, protocol drift, and analysis assumptions need review.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm control, replication, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.

Speaker	Line
Lab manager	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short lab-meeting question set. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: control, replication.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects replication.

Option	Phrase
A	replication
B	control
C	operating constraint
D	decision owner

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Say the data are bad.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	decision owner
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify control and replication against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	approval path
D	operating constraint

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A student presents inconsistent results. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	decision owner
B	Accept the request immediately because the stakeholder has already expressed urgency.
C	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.
D	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the lab-meeting question set with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

4. Research Ethics and Human Subjects

Setting

A researcher wants to use data for a new question outside the approved protocol.

Speaker	Line
Research administrator	Analyze it because the data already exist.
Faculty member	Consent, IRB approval, privacy, and secondary-use rules may apply.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm IRB, informed consent, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Research administrator	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short ethics consultation note. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: IRB, informed consent.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects informed consent.

Option	Phrase
A	evidence threshold
B	approval path
C	operating constraint
D	IRB

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Analyze it because the data already exist.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	decision owner
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify IRB and informed consent against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	approval path
D	operating constraint

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A researcher wants to use data for a new question outside the approved protocol. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	decision owner
B	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the ethics consultation note with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
C	approval path
D	operating constraint

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

5. Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

Setting

A collaborator expects authorship after a small advisory role.

Speaker	Line
Postdoc	Agree to avoid conflict.
External collaborator	Contribution, criteria, order, acknowledgments, and publication norms must be explicit.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm authorship, contribution, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Postdoc	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short authorship agreement draft. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: authorship, contribution.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects contribution.

Option	Phrase
A	operating constraint
B	decision owner
C	contribution

Option	Phrase
D	authorship

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Agree to avoid conflict.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	decision owner
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify authorship and contribution against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	approval path
D	operating constraint

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A collaborator expects authorship after a small advisory role. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Accept the request immediately because the stakeholder has already expressed urgency.
B	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the authorship agreement draft with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
C	operating constraint
D	decision owner

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

6. Peer Review and Revision Responses

Setting

Reviewers ask for additional analyses outside the original scope.

Speaker	Line
Journal editor	Reject the comment sharply.
Author	Tone, evidence, scope, feasibility, and transparent limitations matter.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm peer review, major revision, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Journal editor	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short reviewer-response paragraph. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: peer review, major revision.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects major revision.

Option	Phrase
A	peer review
B	response letter
C	scope
D	evidence threshold

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Reject the comment sharply.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	We should act now and resolve peer review after the result is visible.
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify peer review and major revision against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	operating constraint
D	decision owner

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - Reviewers ask for additional analyses outside the original scope. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	operating constraint
C	decision owner
D	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the reviewer-response paragraph with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

7. Data Management and Reproducibility

Setting

A dataset lacks clear metadata before publication.

Speaker	Line
Data steward	Upload it anyway.
Research team	Metadata, code, provenance, privacy, and repository requirements need attention.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm metadata, repository, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Data steward	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short data-management checklist. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: metadata, repository.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects repository.

Option	Phrase
A	evidence threshold
B	approval path
C	operating constraint
D	metadata

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Upload it anyway.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	I understand the urgency. I need to verify metadata and repository against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
B	We should act now and resolve metadata after the result is visible.
C	A data-management checklist is unnecessary; verbal assurance should be enough.
D	I disagree, but I cannot name the boundary or the decision the group needs to make.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A dataset lacks clear metadata before publication. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.
B	Wait for the problem to become visible before assigning an owner or evidence source.
C	evidence threshold
D	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the data-management checklist with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

8. Academic Presentations and Conferences

Setting

A conference audience challenges the study's generalizability.

Speaker	Line
Conference attendee	Defend every conclusion.
Presenter	Population, context, method, and future work should be addressed calmly.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm generalizability, limitation, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Conference attendee	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short conference Q&A response. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: generalizability, limitation.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects limitation.

Option	Phrase
A	operating constraint
B	generalizability
C	evidence threshold
D	approval path

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Defend every conclusion.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	decision owner
B	We should act now and resolve generalizability after the result is visible.
C	I understand the urgency. I need to verify generalizability and limitation against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
D	operating constraint

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A conference audience challenges the study's generalizability. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the conference Q&A response with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
C	Wait for the problem to become visible before assigning an owner or evidence source.
D	evidence threshold

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

Answer Key and Rationale

Check each stage after completing the practice sequence. The rationale explains the decision skill the strongest response demonstrates.

Research Questions and Study Design - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. research question	'research question' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Research Questions and Study Design - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify research question and hypothesis against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Research Questions and Study Design - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the study-design caveat with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Grant Proposals and Specific Aims - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. specific aims	'specific aims' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Grant Proposals and Specific Aims - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I understand the urgency. I need to verify specific aims and significance against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Grant Proposals and Specific Aims - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the specific-aims revision with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Lab Meetings and Data Challenges - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. control	'control' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Lab Meetings and Data Challenges - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify control and replication against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Lab Meetings and Data Challenges - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the lab-meeting question set with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Research Ethics and Human Subjects - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. IRB	'IRB' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Research Ethics and Human Subjects - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify IRB and informed consent against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Research Ethics and Human Subjects - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the ethics consultation note with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. authorship	'authorship' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify authorship and contribution against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the authorship agreement draft with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Peer Review and Revision Responses - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. peer review	'peer review' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Peer Review and Revision Responses - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify peer review and major revision against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Peer Review and Revision Responses - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the reviewer-response paragraph with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Data Management and Reproducibility - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. metadata	'metadata' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Data Management and Reproducibility - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I understand the urgency. I need to verify metadata and repository against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Data Management and Reproducibility - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the data-management checklist with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Academic Presentations and Conferences - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. generalizability	'generalizability' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Academic Presentations and Conferences - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. I understand the urgency. I need to verify generalizability and limitation against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Academic Presentations and Conferences - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the conference Q&A response with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.